



Traveller's Guide to Beleriand

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Being certain leaves gathered for those who come late over the Blue Mountains, and would go armed into the West.

-- compiled at the Fords of Sarn

You have crossed Ered Luin out of Eriador, and Beleriand lies open before you. It is a fair land and an old one, and much of it is held by folk who will not thank you for wandering in. What follows is set down for the newcomer, and tells where the roads run, whom you may meet upon them, and what a traveller ought to carry. Choose a chapter by its letter. SPACE turns the page and ESC closes the book; '?' brings you back to these contents from anywhere within.

OF THE ROAD HITHER

- (a) Of Coming into Beleriand - the making of a traveller
- (b) Of the Peoples of the West - the kindreds you may claim
- (c) Of Callings and Crafts - what a traveller may be trained to

THE LAND ITSELF

- (d) Of Beleriand and Its Realms - the wilderness and its roads
- (e) A Gazetteer of the Deep Places - the delvings and their tales
- (f) Of Delvings, and How to Walk in Them - doors, stairs, light
- (g) Of the Years - where in the First Age you now stand

THE FOLK YOU WILL MEET

- (h) Of Beasts and Fell Things - the bestiary, by kindred
- (i) Of Companions on the Road - those who will walk with you
- (j) Of Havens and Markets - lodging, trade, and the storehouse

COUNSEL FOR THE ROAD

- (k) Of Arms and the Manner of Fighting
- (l) Of Song and Power
- (m) Of Goods and Gear, and What They Are Worth
- (n) Of the Great Treasures - the artefacts, told lightly
- (o) Of Skin-Changing - the wearing of a beast's form

APPENDICES

- (q) Appendix I: The Ordering of Deeds - every command and its key
- (r) Appendix II: The Marks upon the Map - symbols and colours
- (s) Appendix III: Of the Painted Tiles - the Hither Lands tileset
- (t) Appendix IV: On Settings - the options screens
- (u) Appendix V: On Keymaps and Pref Files
- (v) Appendix VI: Of Matters Best Discovered - skin-changing, SPOILERS

The keys named throughout this book are your own. Change your keyset in the options and the letters in these pages change with you, so what you read here is always what you may press.

Within a chapter, '#' goes to a line, '%' opens another file, '/' searches, and '&' highlights what you name. '-' turns back a page.

Deeper counsel than these leaves can hold is kept by the loremasters at <https://faangband.readthedocs.io/>



Of Coming into Beleriand

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"By the starlit mere of Cuiviénen, Water of Awakening, they rose from the sleep of Ilúvatar..."

-- The Silmarillion, ch. 3

Every hero of the Elder Days began somewhere, and most of them began badly, in a cold country, owning very little, with the strong opinion that somebody ought to do something. Beren came over the mountains of Dorthonion alone and half-starved and made himself into the most famous outlaw of the Age. Tuor was a slave. The tale does not begin when you are ready; it begins when you cross the border, and the border is where you are standing now.

Six screens make a traveller of you, and the arrow keys and ENTER drive them all, in either keyset. Take your time over them. Most of what they settle can never be settled again, and the game is old enough and hard enough that it will not be settling any of it for you out of pity.

The birth screens

They come in order and each narrows the road a little. The first two are the great choices, the third is the one people regret, and the last three are yours to enjoy.

1. RACE - choose among the thirteen peoples, of whom Of the Peoples of the West tells. Stat changes and the experience penalty are shown as you scroll. This decides your kin, your home gate, and who will shut a door in your face.
2. CLASS - choose a calling; of these see Of Callings and Crafts. What the world made you is settled; this is the part you answer for.
3. OPTIONS - birth options are locked for your character's whole life. Two notable defaults: a starting kit of gear (in place of extra gold), and no-selling (shops pay nothing, but you find more gold). Read them once with attention now, and you will not have to wonder about them for the next ten thousand turns.
4. STATS - the point-based buyer is the default and comes pre-filled with sound choices; unspent points become starting gold. The standard roller rolls

instead, and will roll again at your word until you accept. The buyer is the wiser road, though there is an old pleasure in the rolling.

5. HISTORY - edit your background story, if you wish. It changes nothing and it is worth doing anyway; a character with a grandfather in it dies harder.

6. NAME - last of all, the name. End it with a Roman numeral ("Fred I") and your next of that line will succeed it automatically, which is a quiet mercy in a game that kills as freely as this one.

The five stats

Two screens back you were asked to weigh these against one another without being told what they do. This is what they do. Nothing here is decoration; every one of the five is somebody's whole reason for still being alive.

STR - to-hit and damage, carried weight, and extra blows with heavier weapons. The fighter's early friend.

INT - the art of song for mages, rogues, necromancers, and blackguards; also magical devices and disarming.

WIS - the art of song for priests, paladins, druids, and rangers; also your saving throws against magic.

DEX - extra blows with light weapons, to-hit, dodging, locks, and holding onto your purse.

CON - hit points and recovery. Matters most in the deep places, where nothing comes at you once.

Hit points come of your race and class together; the strength to sing, for those who do, grows with level and with the governing stat. Warriors carry no song, and want none. Whatever you are, the first few levels are the thin ones, and more heroes of this Age have been lost in the third week than in the third year.

Where you begin

The last screen fades and you are somewhere real, with a road going

Hither Lands in-game help - standard keyset. Roguelike-keyset players: see the in-game help (?) for y

out of it.

In the wilderness game each race begins in its own home town: Grey-Elves in Menegroth, Dwarves in Belegost, and so on. The folk of the more perilous lands begin above first level, having been seasoned by simply having grown up where they did. In the dungeon-only game all begin equal, at the gate of one deep hold, and the world above is a rumour.

With the Hither Lands tileset your sprite is of your own race, and of whichever gender you chose on the way in -- the step between the map and the roll of the races, a matter of the eye and not the sword. Look down at yourself once before you set out. You will be looking at that small figure for a long while, and if the Age goes as it has gone for everyone else, not long enough.



f the Peoples of the West

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"Now the Children of Ilúvatar are Elves and Men, the Firstborn and the Followers."

-- The Silmarillion, ch. 1

Come down out of the passes of Ered Luin in the morning and look west, and the first thing you will notice is the smoke. It stands in three or four thin columns along the northern sky and it never quite goes out. The second thing you will notice is the traffic. The road under the mountains is not empty, even now; it carries Dwarves with ore and Dwarves with mail, Green-Elf hunters who will not speak to you, Men driving thin cattle east away from the war, and now and then a company of horse going the other way, north, in no hurry to arrive.

Beleriand is a small country with a great many nations in it. In the space of one season on the road you may drink with all of them, and be turned from four doors, and be told four different accounts of who began the trouble. It is worth learning them apart before you need to know whose gate you are hammering upon in the dark.

Thirteen peoples may take up the war against Morgoth, and no two of them go at it alike. Those marked (b) suit a traveller new to the road; those marked (e) ask some seasoning. Each keeps its own home town in the wilderness game, and each will call you kin or stranger accordingly.

The Elves

The Firstborn hold most of what is still free, and they hold it because they have been holding it a long while and mean to go on. An Elf remembers the war from its first day, which is a kind of strength and also a kind of weight; they learn slowly what they do not already know, having already learned so much. Expect long silences, and be careful how you speak of oaths.

High-Elf (e) - Noldor of Gondolin and Nargothrond, mightiest and most burdened; masters of every skill, they see the unseen from birth and start above first level, at the steepest experience cost. They came back over the Sea for the jewels' sake and the Doom of Mandos came with them.

Grey-Elf (e) - Sindar of Thingol's Doriath; strong of arm and will, at home under trees, unharmed by light. They never went into the West and never wanted

to, and they were fighting orcs under starlight
while the Noldor were still learning smithcraft.

Green-Elf (e) - Laiquendi of Ossiriand; hunters and singers,
keen-eyed, silent, deadly with bows, slight in
close battle. They wear green and go barefoot
and you will not see one until it wishes it, and
they have long memories for slaughter.

Dark-Elf - the Moriquendi who never saw the Light; the
stealthiest of all folk, but frail, and the sun
pains them. To travel with one is to travel by
night and rest at noon, and never once to be the
first thing an enemy notices.

Take an Elf and you take the long view of this war, for good and for
ill. The Naugrim in the mountains east take a shorter one, and get
rather more done before dinner.

The Dwarves and the Halflings

The Dwarf-road runs from Belegost and Nogrod under Mount Dolmed and
down into Beleriand, and it is the busiest road in the country. The
Naugrim came to this war as smiths and stayed as soldiers, and they
have never much cared which Elf-king is presently offended. They are
plain dealers, hard bargainers, and the only folk here who can walk
into the deep dark without their nerve going. With them are counted
the halflings, who arrived out of nowhere and no age of this one, and
whom nobody has yet had the heart to send back.

Dwarf - the Broadbeams of Belegost; strong, tough,
never blinded, resistant to sorcery -- and
loud as a forge underfoot. Their lord Azaghâl
put a knife in Glaurung and died of it, and they
will tell you so within the hour.

Longbeard - Durin's Folk of Khazad-dûm, greatest of the
Seven Houses; all a Dwarf's strengths written
larger. Their mansion east of the mountains is
in its morning-glory, and they walk as folk who
have somewhere better to go home to.

Petty-Dwarf - the Noegyth Nibin, Mîm's hunted kindred; the
finest handlers of magical devices alive, free
of movement, and easily broken. They were

hunted for sport before the Elves knew what they were, so they are small, quick, and slow to forgive; a life of hiding teaches the hands everything and the body nothing.

Hobbit (b) - halflings out of a later age; peerless with slings, locks, and shadows, hardy against sickness, feeble in a stand-up fight. Nobody can say how they came here. They do not seem greatly troubled by the question.

The Naugrim will fight beside you and go home again. The Followers have nowhere else to go, which is a different sort of courage.

The Men and the Others

Men came late over the mountains, in the Sun's first years, and found the war already old. They are given seventy years or so and they spend them fast. Some entered the service of the Eldar and were loved; some entered the service of the Enemy and were paid; most only wanted a valley with no orcs in it, and did not get one. With them here are counted the stranger kindreds, the skin-changers and the tree-shepherds who are older than any of us and in no hurry to say so.

Easterling (b) - Men out of the East, the plain measure of mortal kind; sturdy, adaptable, any calling. Their name is under a shadow in these lands and will be under a darker one before the Age ends, which is a poor inheritance for a good soldier.

Adan (e) - the Edain of the Three Houses, friends of the Eldar; surpassing other Men in every field, and their endurance cannot be worn down. Hador, Bëor and Haleth brought their people west into the fire, and their grandchildren are still in it.

Drúadan (e) - the Drúedain, allies of the Haladin; wise, quiet, tough, seeing minds from afar, though towns mistrust them. They sit still for hours and are thought slow; they know where the orcs are, and are thought uncanny for it. Both judgements are made by folk who do not listen.

Beorning (b) - skin-changers of the Anduin vales; hardy

woodsfolk who may take bear-shape with the
'!' command. East of the
mountains they keep bees and mistrust strangers,
and it is thought unwise to be a guest of theirs
past sundown.

Ent - the Onodrim, shepherds of trees; terribly
strong, slow-handed, and wary of fire above all
things. Nothing in Beleriand hits harder or
thinks longer, and nothing else on this list has
watched a forest grow from seed and then watched
it burned.

Choose as you will. The stat tables, the experience costs, and the
full particulars are set out on the race screen at birth as you
scroll. What that screen cannot tell you is which door will open at
midnight when you knock, and that is the choice you are really making.



f Callings and Crafts

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"Aurë entuluva! Day shall come again!"

-- The Silmarillion, ch. 20

A people is what you are born; a calling is what you have done with it since. Every hall in Beleriand is full of folk who chose, some of them badly. The armoury at Barad Eithel is kept by a man who meant to be a loremaster. There is a Green-Elf in Nargothrond who set down her bow forty years ago to learn the making of staves and has not touched a bowstring since, and she is a poor shot now and cares nothing about it.

Nine callings are open to you. Singers draw upon INT or WIS as noted; Warriors draw upon nothing but themselves, as Húrin did, who stood at the Nirnaeth with an axe and no song at all and killed until the axe would not lift. Whichever road you take, take it early. The war will not wait while you decide what you are.

The nine callings

Three of them fight, three of them pray or study, and three walk somewhere in between. What follows is what the muster-rolls would say if muster-rolls were honest.

Warrior - pure battle; the most blows, the best survival by steel alone, no songs, no prayers. Begins with a bonus specialty. A Warrior's answer to an enchantment is to reach the enchanter.

Mage (INT) - feeble at first, near-boundless at last; the best user of wands and staves in the late game. The early years are an apprenticeship paid in bruises, and many do not survive their own beginning.

Priest (WIS)- servant of the Valar; prayers are GRANTED, not chosen, and hafted or blessed weapons please them. You will be given what is needful, which is seldom what you asked for.

Druid (WIS) - keeper of growing things; fights unarmed, charms and commands beasts (of which see Of Companions on the Road). In a country being burned from the north this is not the gentle calling it sounds.

Necromancer (INT) - walks in self-made darkness that light

disrupts; terrible power at a terrible price. The dark must be carried with you and kept unbroken, so a well-lit room is an enemy's best defence.

Paladin (WIS) - the second-best fighter, praying slowly but striking hard; STR and WIS together. A blunt instrument in the hand of something that has an opinion about how it is used.

Rogue (INT) - the best stealth and perception; steals from monsters with 's', sets traps, opens what is shut. A Rogue leaves a hoard lighter and a sleeping dragon none the wiser, most times.

Ranger (WIS)- the master of the bow, with woodcraft and a fair sword-arm besides. The marches of Doriath and the pine-woods of Dorthonion were held for an Age by folk who shot first and were never seen at all.

Blackguard (INT) - a brutal brawler in heavy gear, spending blood for dark sorcery; very hard to kill. The strength comes out of the wound, so a Blackguard who is not bleeding is not yet at work.

None of these is a finished thing. Two Warriors of the same house, armed alike, will not fight alike a year from now, and the reason is below.

Specialties

FAangband's specialty abilities set your character apart from all others of the same calling. You choose one at first level (Warriors choose two), and earn further choices as you prove yourself against the great enemies of the Age, three or four of them in a full life. Review yours with 'S'; singers learn new verses with 'G'.

Consider them the mark the road leaves on you. They are not bought with gold or study but with the deaths of great foes, and there are only so many great foes.

Specialties run from armsmanship, evasion, and shield mastery to channeling, meditation, rapid fire, and stranger arts. Two touch the living world itself. Charm soothes the beasts of the wild so they

never turn on you unprovoked, and Beguile (a Druid specialty) lets you charm animals to your side. Of these also Of Companions on the Road tells.

Choose the first one at birth and you will be living with it for the whole descent, so choose the one that covers the way you already mean to fight, rather than the way you admire from a distance.



f Beleriand and Its Realms

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"...there were mighty convulsions in the earth, and Beleriand was broken and laid waste..."

-- The Silmarillion, ch. 24

That breaking is not yet come upon the land. Ered Luin stands behind you with the snow still lying in its passes, and westward the country falls away league upon league toward a Sea you cannot yet see. There is a whole world there to be walked, and no part of it is safe.

Look west from the last ridge and you will take in most of it at once. The green plains, and the forests dark as standing water, and the grey backs of the mountains, and the rivers that come down out of them loud and cold. Southward the land softens into reed and fen and the slow country of the Seven Rivers. Northward it hardens. Beyond the last of the highlands the grass gives out altogether and there is a dust there that nothing crosses willingly, and past that, if the air is clear, three peaks of slag stand up against the sky with smoke lying flat above them. That is the end of the road, though it is a long way off yet.

Under all of it the deep places are sunk where the old tales say they stood, delvings of dwarves, of elven-kings, and of the Enemy. No tale agrees on how far down any of them goes.

Of the roads between

You will spend more of your life on the road than in any hall, so learn the road first. Region is joined to region by paths, and a path is worked with the same keys as a stair. Stand upon one and press
'<' toward the safer country, or
'>' toward the danger, for depth is danger here
as it is below. Run as Appendix I directs, step warily with
';';, and press 'p' to be drawn on toward
what you have not yet seen.

There is no magic carriage and no horse that will stay with you. You walk, as Beren walked, and you carry what you eat.

By day the wild is lit, and by night you must carry your own light. The beasts of the wilderness are sleeping then, so that the dark hours are quieter than the bright ones and a good deal more frightening. Towns keep their own hours, and their gates do not close, whatever the songs say of prudent folk.

Of the four worlds

Beleriand is not offered to you in one shape only. Four world-maps are laid out at birth, and the choice you make there decides what kind of journey you are agreeing to.

The standard and the extended wildernesses hang the dungeons from an overworld of paths, so that the walking between is itself the tale. The hybrid game spares you the walking and strings the dungeons in sequence through portals. And the plain Angband game forgets Beleriand altogether and keeps one town and one long stair down, with Sauron near the bottom of it, and Morgoth at the last.

Whichever you take, five dungeons anchor the map. Amon Rûdh of the Petty-Dwarves stands first and least, a bald red hill above the moors. Nargothrond is under the Guarded Plain, and Nan Dungortheb under the Mountains of Terror, and Tol-in-Gaurhoth keeps the crossing of the Vale of Sirion. Angband is behind the Gasping Dust, and Angband is last.

Each of them keeps a guardian, and none of the guardians is reasonable. Their tales are told in the Gazetteer, and it is worth reading the tale of a place before you stand in its doorway rather than after.

Of coming home

Nobody walks all the way back. A scroll of Word of Recall will snatch you out of the wild or out of the deeps and set you down in your home town, though not at once; and read at home it will carry you back down to the furthest point of your daring. Read a second scroll to change your mind. Should you come to another town and like it better, press '\$' and your house moves there.

So the country lies. You go out light, you come back heavy, and each time the road you take out begins further down than the last.



Gazetteer of the Deep Places

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"...encompassed within the Girdle of Melian."

-- The Silmarillion, ch. 14

The Hither Lands are Middle-earth itself, the mortal shore east of the Great Sea, and Beleriand is their war-torn west, where this game is set. What follows is what the wise remember of the places you will walk, and the wise are not always right, and some of them are lying.

Take it as a guide is meant to be taken. A name on a map is a promise that somebody was there once and came back to say so. It is not a promise that you will.

The great cities

Four of the free peoples still keep halls worth the name in these years, and a fifth is falling as you read. You will not be welcome in all of them, and you will not find the gate of one of them at all.

Menegroth, the Thousand Caves

Thingol's hall behind the Girdle of Melian, and the fairest dwelling east of the Sea. The Dwarves of Belegost delved it and were paid in pearls out of the water, and they carved the pillars like beeches, with birds of stone in the branches and lamps hung among them. Bright, and old, and closed.

Gondolin, the Hidden Rock

Turgon's white city in its ring of mountains, seven gates deep and not marked on any map that Morgoth has read. The songs say it is found only by those it summons, and the songs are not wrong; the road that brought you there was laid for you before you took it.

Belegost, the Great Fortress

The mansion of the Broadbeam Dwarves under the Blue Mountains, where the mail is made that turns dragon-fire. Their lord Azaghâl wounded Glaurung and was trodden down for it, and his people bore him out on their shoulders singing, and no enemy dared touch them on the road.

Khazad-dûm

The vast eastern mansion of Durin's Folk, in its morning-glory.

Far off, untouched by this war, and rich beyond the telling of it.
Nothing has yet been dug too deep there. That comes later.

Nargothrond

Finrod's cavern-fortress above the Narog, hewn with dwarf-help
until the halls ran a mile under the hill. In these days it is
already a name of dread, and the folk who live within a week's
march of it have stopped saying it aloud.

In a city you may eat, and buy, and sleep with both eyes shut, and that is
the whole of what a city is for. The places that follow are not for any of
those things.

The strongholds of the Enemy and the deep places

These are the delvings the game will actually take you down into. Every
one of them was something else before it was this. That is worth holding
on to on the stairs, when the torch is guttering and the level below is
making a noise you cannot place.

Angband, the Iron Prison

Beneath Thangorodrim, the three peaks of slag that Morgoth heaped
out of his own digging. He sits crowned with stolen light at the
bottom of it and has not left his chair since Fingolfin came alone
to the gate and knocked. The air on the last stair smells of hot
iron. There is nothing under him.

Nan Dungortheb, the Valley of Dreadful Death

A cleft under the Mountains of Terror where Ungoliant's brood
still spins. The water there is bad and the dark is worse, and
the webs are strung across the way at the height of a man's face.
Beren crossed it in his youth and would never afterward say what
he had seen, and men who knew him said he came out grey.

Tol-in-Gaurhoth, the Isle of Werewolves

It was fair Tol Sirion once, and Finrod built a watchtower on it
to hold the pass, and it was the pride of the north. Sauron took
it. Now the howling carries downriver on still nights for miles,
and the boatmen of the Vale will not tie up within sight of the
island, and they are right not to.

Amon Rûdh, the Bald Hill

A red crown of seregon over the moorland, flowering like spilt blood in the late year. Under it Mîm keeps the last halls of the Petty-Dwarves, who were driven out of the west long ago and have forgotten why they should love anyone. It is the shallowest of the deep places, and it is where most travellers learn what a dungeon is.

Begin at Amon Rûdh. Nearly everyone begins at Amon Rûdh. The ones who begin elsewhere are seldom written about, there being nobody left to do it.

The wild regions

Between the delvings lies the country itself, and the country has a temper. Some of these names are places you will cross a dozen times without trouble. Others are the reason the roads bend where they do.

Anfauglith, the Gasping Dust

A green plain until the Sudden Flame came over it in a night and burned the grass to the bone. Now it is ash and grit, and the wind off it tastes of the forge. Nothing lives there that was not sent.

Dorthonion

The highland of pines where Barahir's outlaws held out after the country fell, twelve men and a dog's loyalty, and fell in their turn. The trees are still standing. Little else is.

Doriath, the Fenced Land

Girdled by enchantment, so that the paths bend back on themselves and the traveller walks a day and arrives where he started. It is not malice. It is simply not for you.

Sirion Vale

The pass and course of the great river, the highway of the Age. Every army that has ever mattered has gone up or down this valley, and most of them only once.

Talath Dirnen, the Guarded Plain

Watched from Nargothrond by scouts you will never see, who have counted you since you came over the last rise. Behave yourself.

Ossiriand, the Land of Seven Rivers

Where the Green-Elves sing unseen among the alders, and the water is loud enough that you will hear the singing only when you stop walking. The gentlest country in Beleriand, which is faint praise and still true.

Fen of Serech

A reed-marsh at the throat of the north, where rearguards buy time with blood. They have done it more than once. They will do it again before this is finished.

East over the Blue Mountains lie quieter lands, and out of Eriador, the vales of Anduin, and the Gladden Fields the humbler peoples come. And some names upon the map belong to later songs than this one; walk them gently, for they are visiting, as you are.



f Delvings, and How to Walk in Them

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Beneath every dungeon-marked hill and fortress of the map lie levels without end. The first stair is usually a decent one, cut square, with the marks of the chisel still on it, and you go down it thinking well of whoever made it. Four turns later the cutting stops being square. Somewhere below that it stops being cutting at all and becomes something that was dug by hand, or by claw, and the air changes, and your torch begins to lean toward the draught instead of standing straight.

Such is a delving, repeated as often as your nerve holds. Stand upon a down-stair and press '>' to descend; '<' to ascend.

A level once left is gone forever, for the deeps are vaster than any map, so take what you need the first time. Most levels offer one stair up and two down.

Understand what that means before you are standing in it. There is no going back for the thing you left in the corner. There is no second look at the room you did not open. The deeps do not keep still behind you, and what you walk away from you have given away.

Light

Everything else in this chapter assumes you can see, and that assumption is the first one the dungeon takes off you.

Without light you are blind, and there is no reading, no singing, no picking of locks, no seeing of traps. Carry a torch or a lamp and spare fuel with it, and refuel with 'F' before the dark surprises you. Rooms may be lit or unlit, and the deeper you go the darker they are. Necromancers alone walk lightless, by choice and by art.

A guttering torch four hundred feet down is a worse enemy than most of what lives there, because most of what lives there can wait. Buy the extra flask. It weighs almost nothing and it has never once been the thing that killed anybody.

Traps and doors

Light shows you the room. It does not show you the floor, and the floor is where the trouble is kept.

Traps lie hidden until your wits uncover them, or until you blunder into one; '^' marks those you know of. The uncovering is passive, for there is no search command. Disarm with 'D', and carefully. Trap-detection magic marks out a green zone of safety, but it is a snapshot only, and what the monsters dig afterward it does not know. Doors are '+' when shut and '' when open, and a secret door wears the look of plain granite until you pass close by it. Open with 'o' and close with 'c'.

A shut door behind you is worth more than most songs of warding. Things that hunt by smell lose the trail at a closed door, and things that hunt by sight lose you entirely, and the few that can open doors will announce themselves doing it, which is a courtesy of a kind.

Mining

Sooner or later the way you want goes through the rock, or the rock has something in it that you want, and then you dig.

Quartz veins '*' hold the richest strikes, and magma '%' the lesser. Dig as Appendix I directs, and the game will wield your best digger unbidden.

Always carry one. Rock can close behind you, and a wall is only a wall until you own the tool that disagrees with it; a shovel has saved more lives than many a sword, and it has never yet been cursed.

Reading a level

The dungeon tells you things, if you will stand still long enough to be told.

On arrival the level tells you something of itself, a danger feeling from "quiet and peaceful" to "omens of death", and, as you explore, a promise of treasure from cobwebs to superb. Rest with 'R', survey with 'M', and scroll the map with 'L'.

Learn to trust those feelings and learn when to walk away from one. A level that promises nothing and threatens much is a level you owe nothing to. The stair down is always somewhere, and it is always cheaper than pride.

At the last depth of Angband, past every terror of the descent,
Morgoth himself bars the way down. There is no level beneath him.
There does not need to be.



f the Years

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"...it was named Dagor Aglareb, the Glorious Battle. A victory it was, and yet a warning..."

-- The Silmarillion, ch. 13

You have come in at the end of a very long argument. It began before the Sun and the Moon were made, over three jewels, and it has since eaten two Trees, four kingdoms, and most of the Elves and Men who ever lived in this country. Nobody in Beleriand will explain it to you from the beginning. They assume you know, and they are tired.

The game is set in the First Age of the world, in Beleriand, the land that lay west of the Blue Mountains. As you go down, you go back through the Age's own history. Green realms and guarded kingdoms above, ash and iron below, and at the bottom the beginning of all the trouble. The descent is a reading of the Age backwards. The deeper you stand, the earlier the wound.

The Age in brief

Here is the argument in nine steps, so that when a Grey-Elf spits at the name of Fëanor over the wine, you will know why, and can change the subject.

1. The Elves awake at Cuiviénen and journey west; the Green-Elves turn aside and stay in Ossiriand, and are thought lesser for it by folk who later lost everything.
2. Fëanor makes the Silmarils, and puts into three stones a light that cannot be made twice. Morgoth and Ungoliant destroy the Two Trees and steal them.
3. The Noldor depart under the Doom of Mandos to make war for the jewels' recovery. The Doom is not a curse laid on strangers; it is a promise made to them, and it is kept.
4. The Siege of Angband, the long peace in which Doriath, Nargothrond, and hidden Gondolin flower. Four hundred years of quiet, and everyone alive believed it would hold.
5. Dagor Bragollach, the Battle of Sudden Flame, in which rivers of fire break the Siege. Fingolfin rides to the gate and dies.
He rides alone, in wrath, and no one goes after him.

6. The deeds of Beren and of Túrin, the Quest of the Silmaril, the fall of Nargothrond, the black sword's doom. One tale ends in a marriage, the other in a river, and both are told wherever there is a fire and drink enough.
7. Nírnaeth Arnoediad, the Unnumbered Tears, when treason broke the great alliance of the free peoples. After this there are no more alliances, only holdouts.
8. Gondolin falls, betrayed from within, and the last hidden kingdom goes up in smoke that the northern sky still carries.
9. The War of Wrath, in which the Enemy is thrown down at last -- and that is where you come in.

So runs the Age, in brief. Now stand at the top of the stair and take it the other way.

The road down

Every dungeon is somebody's ruin, and the deeper ones are the older grief. You will not merely read about the fall of these places; you will walk in on the fall itself, still going on, with the same enemy still standing in the same hall.

Five appointed foes mark the descent, and each is a chapter of the tale. Mîm at Amon Rûdh, Glaurung at Nargothrond, Ungoliant in Nan Dungortheb, Sauron at Tol-in-Gaurhoth, and Morgoth himself at the hundredth depth of Angband. Defeat the last and the Age is mended.

What each of their strongholds was in its own day is told in the chapter of places, and it is worth reading before you go down, if only so that you know what you are standing in when the floor of it runs with water and you cannot say why.



f Beasts and Fell Things

=====

"...thus did Melkor breed the hideous
race of the Orcs in envy and mockery
of the Elves..."

-- The Silmarillion, ch. 3

Beleriand is not empty, and little of
what fills it wishes you well. One

who can name a thing before it arrives lives longer than one who cannot,
and and there the argument ends for reading this chapter before you have
need of it rather than after.

Naming is not idle. The kindreds of the north are not one enemy but a
dozen, and what kills one of them will barely inconvenience another.
Fire clears a wood and does nothing to a wight. A blade that has served
you for twenty levels will glance off a spirit. The traveller who dies
in Beleriand generally dies because he treated some new thing as though
it were the last thing.

So look before you strike. Press 'l' and the cursor
will walk from creature to creature, naming each and telling what is
known of it. '/' will name a symbol you do not
know, and '[' lists everything
presently within your sight. Not all of it is your enemy either; of
neutral beasts, and of those who will walk with you, see Of Companions
on the Road.

The great kindreds

What follows is the traveller's rough reckoning of the north, each
kindred with the mark it bears upon the map. Begin with the soldiery,
the bred things that Morgoth makes in quantity and spends without
counting.



Orcs

the hosts of Angband, snaga-slaves driven to war
by greater uruks and by captains worse than these.
upon the map, 'o'



Trolls

stone-hided brutes bred in mockery of Ents; some
cannot bear the light, and know it, and wait.
upon the map, 'T'

Those you will meet in numbers, and numbers are how they are meant to be

met. The next three are a different order of thing. They are not spent by the Enemy but husbanded, being few and slow to make and very hard to replace, and a traveller who meets one has generally been unlucky rather than careless.



Dragons

Glaurung's wingless fire-drakes first, winged terrors later; the colour tells you the element.
upon the map, 'd' and 'D'



Wolves

wargs, and the werewolves of Sauron's breeding; they hunt in packs and they do not tire.
upon the map, 'C' and 'Z'



Spiders

the brood of Ungoliant, spinners of the darkness that lies thick under Nan Dungortheb.
upon the map, 'S'

Against all of those a sword is at least an argument. Against what comes next it often is not. These are the things that are no longer flesh, or never were, and the harm they do is chiefly to what you have spent your career accumulating.



Undead

skeletons, ghosts, liches, wights and wraiths, that drain away what makes you strong.
upon the map, 's z G L W V'



Demons

fire-imps at the least, and at the worst the Balrogs, Maiar of flame with whips of many thongs.
upon the map, 'u' and 'U'



Spirits

ainur and elementals, shifting of shape and hard to wound with any common element.
upon the map, 'A' and 'E'

The remainder are not lesser so much as harder to place. Two of them are Morgoth's eyes rather than his soldiers, one was a tree before it was an enemy, and the last of them chose.



Birds, bats

the crows of Udûn and the bats of Ered Gorgoroth;

Morgoth's eyes are many and they carry word north.
upon the map, 'B' and 'b'



Trees

huorns and worse; fire serves where blades fail,
though the Ents will not thank you for it.
upon the map, 'l'



Giants

hurlers of boulders, to whom a closed door is of
no use to you whatever.
upon the map, 'P'



Men

not all Men kept faith, and the followers of
Ulfang serve the Enemy within reach of here.
upon the map, 'p'

That is the honest shape of it, though Beleriand is untidy and you will
turn up creatures that belong to stranger legends than this one. Take
them as you find them, look at them first, and do not assume that the
rules of one kindred hold for another.

The great names

Beneath the kindreds there are individuals, and they are a different
order of trouble. Deep in Angband wait the named terrors of the Age,
among them Gothmog lord of Balrogs, Glaurung father of dragons,
Ungoliant, Sauron of the werewolves, and Carcharoth at the gate.

None of these is a monster in the sense the rest of this chapter has
meant. Each is a character in a story that was going on long before you
walked into it. Meeting one is not a fight so much as an appointment, and
the wise arrange to be ready for it well beforehand. At the uttermost
depth sits Morgoth Bauglir, the Iron Crown, whom all this war is for,
and to whom every stair you take down is one stair nearer.

Where these stand in the tale of years is told in Of the Years.



f Companions on the Road

=====

"...he swore an oath of abiding friendship and aid in every need to Barahir and all his kin."

-- The Silmarillion, ch. 18

Not all that lives in Beleriand wishes you ill.

Go far enough and you will meet something that does not lift its head as you pass. The world is not divided cleanly into the Enemy and yourself. Between the two there is a great deal of Beleriand still going about its own business, and some of that business can be spoken to.

Consider what it is like. You are two days into Nan Dungortheb with a torch you do not trust, and the webs overhead are thick enough to carry the light sideways. Somewhere behind you a wolf has been keeping pace. You have known it for an hour. What decides whether that is the worst hour of your life or the beginning of a friendship is one question, and it is not a question about your sword. It is a question about what the wolf is, and there is a way to ask.

Reading a stranger

The wise look first. Press 'l' and the cursor walks from creature to creature, naming each, and beside the name it sets down the creature's temper in a single word. There are four such words, and they carry most of what this chapter has to teach.

aggressive it means you harm. "(unaware)" means it has not yet noticed you, which is a gift, and gifts of that kind do not keep.

neutral it lets you be unless provoked. Territorial animals are marked "territorial"; give them room and they will give you yours.

aligned it is fighting your enemies, or follows you. Enemies of your enemy are common in this Age and cost nothing.

following it is one of your own followers, and will come when you go.

The monster list, '[', is the same knowledge gathered into one place, and it marks your helpers with an "(allied)" tag so you can count heads before opening a door. In ASCII mode the colours speak as well. Neutral folk of the Free Peoples are tinted green, and bright green when they fight for you; territorial

beasts are yellow, and other wild animals umber. With graphics tiles those tints do not apply, since a painted wolf is only a wolf, so let the look command and the monster list answer for you instead.

The asking

There is no eloquence in it, and no oratory. The deed is called "Recruit a monster", and in the standard keyset it answers to 'j'. Press it, then a direction toward an ADJACENT neutral creature, and you will have said whatever it is that gets said at such moments.

In the roguelike keyset 'j' walks south instead, so the command must be reached another way. Open the command menu with ENTER and find it under "Hidden", or bind a keymap of your own. Arrange it early in a quiet corridor rather than a loud one.

What follows the asking is a contest, and these are its terms.

Who may join: neutral people of the Free Peoples, that is, the speaking races. A character with the Beguile ability, which is a Druid specialty, may also charm wild animals that are not evil.

The reckoning is a weighing of your level against the creature's. Great folk will not lightly follow the untried, and they are not wrong to weigh you.

Giving offence is easily done. Fail against a much greater creature, more than five levels above you, and it takes the asking as an insult and turns hostile. A milder failure leaves it merely unconvinced, and you may try again.

How many you may lead: 1 follower, plus one more at level 15 and another at level 30. Three is as much company as Beleriand will allow any one traveller.

The cost -- parley takes a game turn, whether or not it succeeds. In an empty wood that is nothing at all. With something coming down the passage behind you it is a great deal.

Parting is done the same way it was begun. Parley with a follower a second time and it leaves off following you and returns to neutrality, and there is no quarrel in it. Beasts do not sulk. Whether you ought to feel anything about it is a matter between you and your conscience.

Walking with a wolf

Hither Lands in-game help - standard keyset. Roguelike-keyset players: see the in-game help (?) for y

Allies need no orders, which is the first mercy. You will not spend your dungeon managing anybody. A follower seeks out your enemies within its hearing and fights them, and when no enemy is near it walks with you, and there is no more to the arrangement than that.

What it changes is not chiefly the arithmetic of a fight. It is the corridor behind you. A companion means one direction you no longer have to watch, and in Nan Dungorthëb that is worth more than armour. You will find yourself listening for it. You will find that when it falls behind at a corner you stop and wait, which is not a thing you did before you had one.

An ally never turns on you of its own will. It may be killed, and often is, for it does not know how deep you have brought it and would not turn back if it did. But strike or rob one and it will remember, as the sons of Ulfang taught the Union of Maedhros that a false friend is worse than an open foe.

The temper of the wild

It helps to remember that most of what lives in Beleriand is not at war with you. Animals and growing things begin neutral rather than hostile, and each kind has its own notion of what you are.

Territorial beasts attack if you press into their ground, and only if you press into it; the ground is theirs and the pressing is yours. Skittish ones flee, and go on fleeing, and running one down a long passage is how travellers come to meet the things that live at the end of long passages. Molds and mushrooms strike only what stands beside them, so the whole of that difficulty is solved by standing somewhere else. There is a great deal of Beleriand you may simply walk past.

Not all of it, of course. Evil things, the undead, and the creatures of Morgoth are enemies always, and no word of yours will alter that, and the traveller who stops to reason with a wight has misunderstood the wight.

A character with the Charm ability moves among beasts without alarming them, which is less a power than a manner. The rest of us make do with courtesy, distance, and the sense to look before we strike. Of the beasts themselves, and how to know one kindred from another, see Of Beasts and Fell Things.

"But Huan the hound was true of heart."

-- The Silmarillion, ch. 19



f Havens and Markets

=====

You will come up out of the wild at dusk, most times, with the weight all wrong on your back and blood on something, and you will see lamps. That is a town. There is no wall worth the name and no watch that will stop you, and the first thing you

hear is somebody arguing about a price.

The towns of the free peoples shelter four or nine numbered doors, and the townsfolk between them -- urchins, drunks, and worse, hardly worth a blow, and sometimes worth some care for your purse.

Nobody in a town will ask where you have been. They can tell. What they want to know is what you brought back, and whether you can pay, and the second question is the one they ask out loud.

The shops

The doors are numbered rather than named, which offends the poets and suits everyone else. Walk onto a numbered door to go in.



General Store

food, torches, oil, cloaks, picks and shovels; the town's dependable larder.



Armoury

mail and shields, richer as you prove yourself below.



Weaponsmith

blades, bows, and ammunition, and the loudest forge on the street to find it by.



Bookseller

the simpler books of every realm, shelved by a man who has read none of them.



Alchemist

potions and scrolls, Word of Recall among them, which is the errand you will keep coming back for.



Magic Shop

rings, amulets, wands, and staves; sell a spent wand and buy it back recharged.



Black Market

anything at all, for far too much, and no questions asked in either direction.



Home

your own storeroom, and the one honest price in town.

The General Store and the Alchemist are the two you will wear out. The Black Market you will visit once, out of curiosity, and come away insulted, and go back.

Within a shop, 'p' or 'g' buys, 's' or 'd' sells (or stashes, at home), 'l' or 'x' examines a ware, and ESC takes you out again.

There is no haggling. These are war years and everyone has one price.

The terms of trade

Learn the habits of shopkeepers early, because they are stranger than they look and they are not in your favour.

By the default birth options the shops will pay nothing for your loot, and your gold must come out of the deeps instead. Shopkeepers refuse what they know to be dross, and they will buy an unknown thing with a merchant's confidence, so that selling a mystery is a fair way to learn what it was. Stock shifts only while you are long away; what you sold may be gone when you return, and a shop bought empty restocks entirely.

So a town rewards leaving it. Go down, stay down, come back changed, and the shelves will have changed with you. Hover about the market for a week and you will find the same three cloaks looking at you.

Nothing here is quite as it was in the songs -- no market of Menegroth, no forges of Nogrod -- but a shovel bought is a shovel, in any Age.



f Arms and the Manner of Fighting

=====

"That knife was made by Telchar of Nogrod...
iron it would cleave as if it were green
wood."

-- The Silmarillion, ch. 19

There is a great deal of fighting in Beleriand and very little of it is glorious. The songs keep the duels. Fingolfin at the gate, Fingon on the height, Húrin standing over the last of his guard in the Fen of Serech. What they leave out is the long ugly middle of every battle, and that is where you will be spending your time. The Enemy does not fight to be remembered. He fights with numbers, and with poison, and with things that were men once, and he can afford to lose.

So fight the way the survivors of this Age fought. Know what is in front of you before it is on top of you. Keep a road at your back. Be faster than the thing you are killing, and where you cannot be faster, be somewhere else. Everything below is only the detail of that.

Melee

Most of it comes down to standing next to something and hitting it until one of you stops. Walk into a foe and you strike it. Bare hands are a poor argument in Beleriand, so bear a weapon and take it up with 'w'.

Each blow rolls your skill against the target's armour, and a miss is no damage at all. Weapon damage is its dice plus enchantment, and your blows per round grow with STR and DEX and shrink with the weapon's weight. Warriors reach six blows, pure singers four, the rest five. Rings and other worn gear add their to-hit and to-dam to your melee strikes.

The old quarrel between the heavy blade and the quick one is settled differently for every arm that lifts them. A weapon you swing twice is generally worth more than a weapon you swing once and harder, unless the once is enough, and against certain things it is. Carry both a while and let the corpses decide.

Shooting and throwing

The better part of any fight in these lands is over before the enemy

arrives. Beleg Cúthalion killed at a distance for thirty years and was scarcely ever seen doing it, and a bow remains the only argument that lets you win without being hit.

Fire ammunition with 'f', or loose at the nearest foe without aiming. Appendix I gives that key for your keyset. Throw things with 'v'. Only a matching launcher gives ammunition its full power, for the bow's multiplier scales the whole shot. Choose your mark with '*', or take the closest foe with '''.
'''.

Arrows run out, and there is no fletcher under the mountains. Gather what you have shot once the floor is quiet, keep something plain for the crowds, and save the good ammunition for whatever the crowd is standing in front of.

Armour and resistance

Mail is a slow answer to a fast problem, and it is still the best answer anybody in the Elder Days has found. The Noldor did not go to war in cloth. Neither should you, and neither should you imagine that iron alone will see you through, because most of what wants you dead down there does not intend to use iron on you at all.

Armour class turns blows aside and softens what lands, though heavy body armour costs a little accuracy. Elemental resistances are percentages that stack multiplicatively, and temporary resistance adds another layer. Fire, cold, acid, lightning, poison, and confusion are the six to secure first. The elements ruin your goods as well. Fire eats scrolls, acid eats armour, cold eats potions, and lightning eats rings and wands, so resistance guards your pack too.

A traveller who has been burned once tends to buy resistance the way other people buy bread, and that is the right instinct. Sooner or later the cold gets past the mail, and then the only thing between you and the floor is what you took the trouble to resist.

Perils of the deep

Deeper down, the fight stops being about weapons. The old horrors of this Age did not need to touch you to finish you. Glaurung unmade an army with his breath and a princess with his eyes, and the wights in the barrows take something from a man that no leech can put back.

Learn these before you meet them, because meeting them is the expensive way.

Dragon-breath takes a share of the beast's own vigour, less at a distance, for there is no dodging it, only resisting. The undead drain your experience, and hold life is the true shield there. Stunning spoils your aim and your songs; free action wards off magical paralysis. Speed is the king of stats, and ten points of it doubles you.

Take that last one seriously. Two of you against one of them is not a metaphor, and every deep-dweller who ever came back up did so because they were quicker than the thing behind them.

The advantage runs both ways, and the Enemy's creatures may be afflicted in their turn. Stun, confuse, slow, frighten or hold them, and every such state opens them to heavier critical strikes. A blinded troll is barely a troll. Cripple first and kill after, and you will find that Beleriand is survivable, which is the most that anyone in this Age was ever promised.



f Song and Power

=====

"For Felagund strove with Sauron in songs of power,
and the power of the King was very great; but Sauron
had the mastery."

-- The Silmarillion, ch. 19

That is the shape of magic in the Elder Days. Two beings stand in a dark place and sing at one another, and the stronger song bends the weaker, and the loser goes down. There are no gestures here and no smoke. Power in this Age is sung, and prayed, and studied, and it comes out of who you are and what you have been given rather than out of any trick of the fingers.

Finrod Felagund lost that contest and it cost him his crown, his company and his life, and he is still counted among the mighty for having come as close as he did. Bear that in mind on the days when a song fails you. The greatest singer in Beleriand was beaten by a lieutenant, and it was a near thing.

Four realms of five books each serve the four kinds of singer, and which realm is open to you was settled at your birth, when you chose what you would be.

Arcane (INT) - the Mage's study, and a little of the Rogue's.

Shadow (INT) - the Necromancer's dark road; the Blackguard borrows its destructions.

Holy (WIS) - the Priest's prayers, granted by the Valar in their own order, not chosen; the Paladin prays more slowly and never reaches the highest.

Nature (WIS) - the Druid's verses; the Ranger sings the survival-songs of wood and trail.

Warriors carry no song and want none. Pure singers use all five books of their realm, and the hybrid callings only the first few. The hybrids are not lesser people for it; a Ranger who can heal his own arm in the field has settled an argument the Mage is still having with a book.

Singing

A song must be learned before it can be sung, and no one has ever learned one usefully while being eaten. Everything in this section

is work you do in the quiet, so that the loud part goes better.

These pages speak of song, which is how the loremasters of the First Age spoke of such power. Your character sheet still reckons the strength for it as SP, the old shorthand, but the art is the same.

Sing or pray with 'm', browse a book with 'b', and learn new songs with 'G' when your level allows. A song takes a full turn. Failure starts common and grows rare with level, and the great singers come to fail not at all.

Singing beyond your strength is possible, and it asks a price. The attempt may leave you drained, or paralyzed mid-word.

Every art has its conditions, and no singer has ever talked one of them round. You cannot sing blind or confused, and every singer but the Necromancer needs light to read by. The Necromancer reads the dark itself, and light is a wound to that art.

What you wear is one of those conditions. Mail is a weight on the singer. Carry more armour than your calling was meant to bear and the measure of song you can hold falls away, one for every ten units of excess, and they come back the moment the weight is set down. The allowance is widest for the Blackguard, who was never expected to travel light, and narrowest for the Mage and the Necromancer, whose strength was never meant to be worn. Priest, Druid, Rogue, Paladin and Ranger stand between. Those who take the Armor Proficiency specialty are granted a little more room before the penalty begins.

Gloves are the one mercy. In other worlds a singer's hands must go bare; here they need not. A glove is only the weight it is, and nothing about it dulls a voice or a hand.

Devices

There is a second kind of power, older in a sense, because it was put into the thing by somebody else and only waits there for a hand. A wand does not care whether you were taught. This is how the unlearned of Beleriand fight fire, and there is no shame in it whatever.

Wands are aimed with 'a', staves used with 'u', rods zapped with 'z', and worn things activated with 'A'. Devices obey skill and not realm, and even a Warrior may lean on a good wand,

though it is the Mage who outshoots everyone with them in the end.

Which is the way of things. The one who understands how the making was done gets the most out of what was made, and that has been true in these lands since the first forge was lit.



f Goods and Gear

=====

"The heart of Fëanor was fast
bound to these things that he
himself had made."

-- The Silmarillion, ch. 7

Fëanor is the warning at the head of this chapter and not the model. The greatest craftsman who ever lived bound his heart to three jewels, and burned the ships, and dragged his whole people into a ruin that is still going on around you. Things are dangerous. Not because they are cursed, though some are, but because a traveller who will not put a thing down when the time comes to run will be found later, still holding it.

Still, no one ever walked into Angband empty-handed on purpose. Let us be practical about the carrying.

Carrying

A traveller's pack in the Elder Days is a small and jealous country, and everything you put into it you have chosen not to put something else. Walk onto an item to take it, or gather it with 'g'. The pack holds twenty-three kinds of thing, each stacking to forty, and twelve more places are worn upon your body. Weight past your strength slows you. Wear or wield with 'w', take off with 't', drop with 'd', and inscribe with '{', and your notes ride along with the item.

Inscription is worth more than it looks. The dungeon is long and memory is short, and a word cut into the haft of a wand will still be there in an hour, when you have forgotten what the wand was for and something with too many legs is coming up the corridor.

Knowing what you have

The hard part of this Age is that nothing tells you what it is. The loremasters who could name a thing on sight are behind you in Menegroth and Nargothrond, and they are not coming down here. What you carry, you carry on trust, until it has proved itself one way or the other.

Every potion, scroll, ring and amulet kind wears a random

disguise each game ("a copper ring") until it is learned. There is no scroll of Identify in this Age, and knowledge is earned. Weapons and armour reveal their runes as you fight in them; devices reveal themselves in use, so aim them at something easy first; scrolls teach by reading, which is safest done standing on stairs; potions and mushrooms teach the bold. Shopkeepers know their trade also, and selling an unknown thing reveals it.

Unknown properties show as {??}, and the game marks {cursed}, {tried}, and {empty} as it learns alongside you.

So the pack fills with half-known things, and each of them is a small wager. This is the ordinary condition of everyone who has ever gone under a mountain looking for treasure, and there is no cure for it except going under the mountain again.

Ignoring the dross

Rubbish accumulates faster than gold. Every orc you kill leaves a bent dagger behind it, and after the fortieth bent dagger the floor stops meaning anything and you begin to walk past the things that matter.

The ignore command puts an item, or its whole kind, out of your sight, and 'K' shows or hides everything so dismissed. Appendix I gives the ignore key for your keyset. Quality levels let you sweep all bad gear from sight at once.

Use it early and use it hard. A clean floor is a floor you can read at a glance, and reading the floor at a glance is occasionally the difference between leaving a level and staying on it.

Keeping things whole

The last thing to understand about property in Beleriand is that it does not last. Nothing here does. The Enemy's servants throw fire and frost about with no thought for what is in your pack, and the scroll you were saving is a handful of ash the moment a fire-hound gets a look at it.

The elements are enemies of property. Fire eats scrolls and staves, acid armour and ammunition, frost potions, lightning rings, wands, and rods. Your pack gives a thing some chance to survive; the bare floor gives none. Resist the element and your goods resist with you, of which more in Of Arms

and the Manner of Fighting.

Which brings the matter back round to Fëanor. Hold your gear loosely enough to lose it, and keep the spare in the pack rather than on the ground, and you will part with less than he did.



f the Great Treasures

=====

"In that time were made those things that afterwards were most renowned of all the works of the Elves."

-- The Silmarillion, ch. 7

The great works of the Age lie hidden in Beleriand, waiting.

You have come late to the making. Nearly every famous thing you may lift out of the dark was hammered out before you were born, by hands that are mostly dust now, for a purpose that was not yours. There is one of each, and there will never be another. A great treasure is not simply a better sword. It is a piece of somebody else's story that you have picked up, and it is heavier than it looks.

They do not announce themselves. A nameless blade and a named one sit much the same in the hand, and what you come to understand of the second you will learn by carrying it into trouble. What you have understood so far, 'I' will tell you back. The rest is in the songs, and the songs are not always kind.

Here are a few of the names you may meet below, and what is remembered of them.



Ringil

The sword of Fingolfin, High King of the Noldor, that glittered like ice. When his people had been broken on the Anfauglith he rode alone to the gates of Angband and knocked upon them, and called Morgoth out to single combat. With Ringil he dealt the Enemy seven great wounds, and Morgoth has gone lame ever since. The High King did not come back.



Angrist

"Iron-cleaver," forged by Telchar of Nogrod, carried out of Nargothrond by Curufin and taken from him by Beren. It cut a Silmaril free of the Iron Crown without complaint. Then Beren, who never knew when a thing was finished, tried for a second stone, and the blade snapped, and a shard of it flew and struck the cheek of Morgoth, and Morgoth stirred in his sleep.



Gurthang

"Iron of Death," the black sword of Túrin Turambar, reforged out of Anglachel, which was made of iron that fell from heaven. It was cold, and it was malicious, and it spoke, and it did not forget what it had been asked to do. At the end Túrin asked it whether it would drink his blood, and it answered that it would, and gladly.



Anguirel

Eöl the Dark Elf made two blades out of a fallen star. One he gave away and one he kept, and this is the one he kept. His son Maeglin stole it from him and bore it into Gondolin, and it was not the last thing Maeglin took that was not his.



Aranrúth

"King's Ire," the sword of Elu Thingol of Doriath, who was a king in these lands before there were any Noldor here to argue with him. It came out of the ruin of Menegroth when very little else did, and went down the long years afterward to the hands of the Kings of Númenor.



Glamdring and Orcrist

Foe-hammer and Goblin-cleaver, made in Gondolin for the war and paired as brothers are paired. They burn cold when orcs come near, which is a courtesy the smiths built into them on purpose. Both of them outlast the city that made them. Long after this Age has become a song, strangers who cannot read their runes will pull them out of a troll's cave.



The Dragon-helm of Dor-Lómin

The Helm of Hador, grey steel crowned with the likeness of Glaurung in gold, made by Telchar and handed down a line of lords who each in turn found it too heavy to wear. Túrin wore it. The servants of Morgoth fled the sight of it, which was the whole purpose of the thing.



Belthronding

The great black bow of Beleg Cúthalion, cut of yew, that no other archer ever bent. Beleg was the truest friend Túrin had, and Túrin killed him in the dark by mistake, in the moment when Beleg was cutting him loose from his bonds. The bow was buried with the archer.



The Elessar

The green Elfstone, in which a little of the light of the elder Sun was caught, so that withered things seen through it looked young again, and hurt things touched by the hand that held it were made whole. It was wrought in Gondolin and given for love, and its fame runs clean out the far end of this Age.



Nimphelos

A pearl the size of a dove's egg, white as starlight, that Thingol paid to the Dwarves of Belegost for their labour in the

delving of Menegroth. Their lord held it worth more than a mountain of gold and said so aloud, which from a Dwarf is an extravagance.



Camlost

"Empty-handed." Beren took that name for himself when he came back to Thingol's hall and lifted his arm and there was no hand on the end of it, and no Silmaril in the hand, Carcharoth having taken the two of them together. The gauntlets remember what the hand held.

Not all of the great work of the Age was done in the light. Weapons and armour of the Enemy's making lie below also -- black things of meteor-iron and worse, hammered out in Angband for hands unlike yours, and they are not always the poorer for it. Whether to wield them is your own affair. Many have. A few were even glad of it afterward.

It helps to know the hands that did the work, for you can often read a thing's parentage off its surface. The smiths of the Age worked in ranks of matter: dwarf-iron grey and runed, elven steel blue-white, meteor-iron black with a glint of stars, and rarest of all, work that saw the Light of Valinor itself and kept some of it.

Carry such things well, and do not be too proud of them. Every one of them outlived the person it was made for, and every one of them will outlive you. None of them has ever saved anybody who was set on being a hero. They are only the best tools in the world.



f Skin-Changing

=====

"Then Sauron shifted shape, from wolf to serpent, and from monster to his own accustomed form..."

-- The Silmarillion, ch. 19

Skin-changing is an old art, and not the Enemy's alone.

Sauron wore the wolf and the serpent because they served him, and they served him well. But the craft is older than his use of it, and there are those who put on another skin for reasons he would not recognise. Some callings learn it out of books. One people is simply born to it.

What the changing is like is hard to set down, and those who can do it are not much help, since they mostly shrug. The nearest a traveller gets is this. You are yourself, and then the ground is closer, and the dark has stopped being dark and has become a set of shapes you can smell. Your hands are gone and you do not miss them. You want to run, not out of fear, but because running has become the obvious thing to do with a body. And underneath all of it you are still there, keeping accounts, deciding where to go. That last part is the whole difference between skin-changing and madness, and it holds.

Who shifts

The art is not open to everyone, and those it is open to come at it by four different roads.

Druids take the shapes of beast and stone through their nature verses. Theirs is the widest road and the gentlest, and it ends in a bear.

Necromancers wear the forms of the creatures of night, which are quicker and stronger than a Druid's and are not given freely.

Blackguards learn one savage shape of their own, and one is enough for what a Blackguard intends to do with it.

A Beorning needs no verse at all, for bear-shape is that people's birthright, taken at will with '!', and it deepens as they grow.

And any hero whatever, wearing the right dragon-scale armour, may briefly know what it is to be a dragon. That is the shortest road of the lot and the dearest, and nobody who takes it once forgets it.

Wearing another skin

Shapes are entered by singing the form's verse with 'm', by the Beorning's '!', or by the power of certain items. Whichever door you come in by, what waits beyond it is the same. In a shape you ARE the beast. Its blows are yours, and its senses, and its stealth, and its hide. Your worn equipment stays on you, changed with you, and all its virtue still counts, which is the one great mercy of the art and the reason anyone bothers.

But paws cannot turn pages. That is the whole of the difficulty, and it is not a small one. In beast-form your pack is closed to you, and there is no reading, no singing, no wands, and no swapping of gear. You may eat from the floor and little else. Attempt anything handier and the game will ask whether you would care to be a person again first, which is a courteous way of saying that you have forgotten what you are.

The moment this matters is always the same moment. Something has gone wrong, and the answer to it is in your pack, and you are a fox.

Returning

Press '!' to take your own shape again. The changing back costs nothing, and say it plainly that there is no trap in this art. Nobody in Beleriand gets stuck as a wolf.

A shape is a tool. Put it on for the work it is good at, which is travel, or stealth, or slaughter, and take it off again to think. The skin-changers who come to grief are not the ones who shift too often. They are the ones who forget that they have shifted.

With the Hither Lands tileset your figure upon the map changes with you, every form having its own sprite, so you need not remember by willpower alone.

The full particulars of every shape, and there are twenty-two of them, are set out with numbers and all in Appendix VI, Of Matters Best Discovered, for those who would rather know than wonder.

Original Keyset Command Summary

=====

^ followed by a letter is an abbreviation for pressing and releasing the letter key with the control key also depressed. You may also press and release ^ and then press and release the letter key to activate the same command in case your system intercepts the control plus key combination and does not pass it on. The `autoexplore_commands` option modifies the '<', '>', and 'p' commands. When that option is off (that is the default), the commands act as described below. When that option is on, '<' or '>' will use the staircase at the player's location if it is the appropriate kind of staircase or will move to the nearest known staircase of the appropriate kind if the player is not already at that kind of staircase. 'p' will move to the nearest unexplored location when the `autoexplore_commands` option is on.

a	Aim a wand	A	Activate an object
b	Browse a book	B	-
c	Close a door	C	Character description
d	Drop an item	D	Disarm a trap or lock a door
e	List equipped items	E	Eat some food
f	Fire an item	F	Fuel your lantern/torch
g	Get objects on floor	G	Learn new songs/prayers
h	Fire default ammo at target	H	-
i	List contents of pack	I	Inspect an item
j	Recruit a monster	J	-
k	Ignore an item	K	Toggle ignore
l	Look around	L	Locate player on map
m	Sing a song	M	Display map of entire level
n	Repeat previous command	N	-
o	Open a door or chest	O	-
p	- (see above)	P	-
q	Quaff a potion	Q	Retire character & quit
r	Read a scroll	R	Rest for a period
s	Steal from a monster (rogues)	S	View abilities (specialties)
t	Take off equipment	T	Dig a tunnel
u	Use a staff	U	Use an item
v	Throw an item	V	Display version info
w	Wear/wield equipment	W	Walk into a trap
x	-	X	-
y	-	Y	-
z	Zap a rod	Z	-
!	Change shape (Beornings)	^a	(special - debug command)
@	-	^b	-
#	Check time	^c	(special - break)

\$	Move house	^d	-
%	-	^e	Toggle inven/equip window
^	(special - control key)	^f	Repeat level feeling
&	-	^g	Do autopickup
*	Target monster or location	^h	-
(	-	^i	(special - tab)
)	Dump screen to a file	^j	(special - linefeed)
{	Inscribe an object	^k	-
}	Uninscribe an object	^l	Center map
[	Display visible monster list	^m	(special - return)
]	Display visible object list	^n	-
-	-	^o	Show previous message
_	-	^p	Show previous messages
+	Alter grid, set monster trap	^q	-
=	Set options	^r	Redraw the screen
;	Walk (with pickup)	^s	Save and don't quit
:	Take notes	^t	-
'	Target closest monster	^u	-
"	Enter a user pref command	^v	-
,	Stay still (with pickup)	^w	(special - wizard mode)
<	Go up staircase (see above)	^x	Save and quit
.	Run	^y	-
>	Go down staircase (see above)	^z	-
\	(special - bypass keymap)	~	Check knowledge
`	(special - escape)	?	Display help
/	Identify symbol		
	List contents of quiver		

Symbols On Your Map

=====

Symbols on your map can be broken down into three categories: Features of the dungeon such as walls, floor, doors, and traps; Objects which can be picked up such as treasure, weapons, magical devices, etc; and creatures which may or may not move about the dungeon, but are mostly harmful to your character's well being.

Some symbols are used to represent more than one type of entity, and some symbols are used to represent entities in more than one category. The "@" symbol (by default) is used to represent the character.

It will not be necessary to remember all of the symbols and their meanings. The "slash" command ('/') will identify any character appearing on your map (see 'commands.txt').

Note that you can use a "user pref file" to change any of these symbols to something you are more comfortable with.

Features that do not block line of sight

.	A floor space	1	Entrance to General Store
.	A trap (hidden)	2	Entrance to Armoury
^	A trap (known)	3	Entrance to Weapon Smith
;	A glyph of warding	4	Entrance to Bookseller
'	An open door	5	Entrance to Alchemy Shop
'	A broken door	6	Entrance to Magic Shop
<	A staircase up	7	Entrance to the Black Market
>	A staircase down	8	Entrance to your Home
#	A pool of lava		

Features that block line of sight

#	A secret door	#	A wall
+	A closed door	%	A mineral vein
+	A locked door	*	A mineral vein with treasure
:	A pile of rubble	:	A pile of passable rubble

Objects

!	A potion (or flask)	/	A pole-arm
?	A scroll (or book)		An edged weapon
,	A mushroom (or food)	\	A hafted weapon
-	A wand or rod	}	A sling, bow, or x-bow
_	A staff	{	A shot, arrow, or bolt
=	A ring	(	Soft armour
"	An amulet	[	Hard armour
\$	Gold or gems	]	Misc. armour
~	Lights, Tools, Chests, etc	)	A shield
&	Multiple items		

Monsters

\$	Creeping Coins	,	Mushroom Patch
a	Giant Ant	A	Ainu
b	Giant Bat	B	Bird
c	Giant Centipede	C	Canine (Dog)
d	Dragon	D	Ancient Dragon
e	Floating Eye	E	Elemental
f	Feline (Cat)	F	Dragon Fly
g	Golem	G	Ghost
h	Humanoid	H	Hybrid
i	Icky-Thing	I	Insect
j	Jelly	J	Snake
k	Kobold	K	Killer Beetle
l	Tree/Ent	L	Lich
m	Mold	M	Multi-Headed Hydra
n	Naga	N	-
o	Orc	O	Ogre
p	Human "person"	P	Giant "person"
q	Quadruped	Q	Quylthulg (Pulsing Flesh Mound)
r	Rodent	R	Reptile/Amphibian
s	Skeleton	S	Spider/Scorpion/Tick
t	Townsperson	T	Troll
u	Minor Demon	U	Major Demon
v	Vortex	V	Vampire
w	Worm or Worm Mass	W	Wight/Wraith
x	-	X	Xorn/Xaren
y	Yeek	Y	Yeti
z	Zombie/Mummy	Z	Zephyr Hound

With the Hither Lands tileset

When graphics tiles are on (see the Options help file), sprites stand in for the symbols above; the symbols remain what you see in ASCII mode, in the '/' identify command, and in any frontend that cannot draw tiles. The green, yellow, and umber disposition tints described in the Allies help file are likewise ASCII-only -- with tiles on, use the look command and the monster list instead.

Appendix III: Of the Painted Tiles

=====

Hither Lands draws the whole game -- terrain, monsters, objects, and you -- as painted tiles in a single warm palette, made for this First-Age setting. This file covers what the tileset adds and how to turn it on.

Turning tiles on

Tiles work in the SDL2 interface only (never in the terminal). Start the game with the SDL2 frontend, load or create a character, and once you stand at the main command prompt open the menu bar at the top of the window and follow it through

FAangband -> Tiles -> Set -> Hither Lands

Then under Tiles -> Size, keep the width about twice the height (width 6, height 3 suits the 10x20 font). Your choice is saved and holds for later sessions.

What the tileset adds

- | | |
|---------------------|--|
| Animated tiles | - torchlight flickers and water shimmers on their own, even while the game waits for your move. No option needed. |
| Shapechange sprites | - take another form (a Beorning's bear, a druid's shapes, the '!' command) and your figure on the map changes with you. |
| Per-race sprites | - you appear as your own race, and so do the people of the Free Races you meet below; a female-flagged foe shows a female figure. |
| Your own figure | - the player sprite's gender is chosen at character generation, on the step between the map and race menus, and kept in your savefile. |

Light and dark themes

Press F12 at any time to toggle between the dark palette (the default) and a light palette. The colours invert while the tile art stays the same; it is a display preference, not a gameplay change. Your choice is saved

and restored when you next load the game.

What stays ASCII

The disposition colour-tints described in Of Companions on the Road belong to ASCII mode; with tiles on, read dispositions with the look command and the monster list instead. The '/' command always answers in symbols, whatever is drawn on the map.

Options

=====

Press '=' (both keysets) to interact with options. User Interface options may be changed at any time; Birth options are fixed for a character's whole life and matter only when a new one is made. On the option pages, 's' saves your settings as defaults for later characters and 'r' resets to the defaults for new characters.

The two keysets

The FIRST entry on the User Interface page is "Rogue-like commands". Off (the default), you use the original keyset shown in the commands help file; on, you use the roguelike keyset, where the letters hjklyubn walk and their capitals run. This help system follows you: '?' opens the reference for whichever keyset is active.

User interface options worth knowing

Always pickup items	- no prompt to gather what you step on
Use old target by default	- keep shooting the same foe
Show damage player deals	- numbers with your blows
Disturb whenever viewable monster moves	- safer, noisier
Automatically clear -more- prompts	- faster, riskier
Player color indicates low hitpoints	- '@' warns you in ASCII
Show unique monsters in purple	- the great foes stand out
Center map continuously	- the view follows you
Notify on object recharge	- know when the rod is ready
Use sound	- as it says

Birth options worth knowing

Start with a kit of useful gear	- gear instead of gold (default on)
Increase gold but disable selling	- shops buy nothing (default on)
Show level feelings	- sense a level's promise
Generate levels with connected stairs	
Force player descent + Word of Recall has no effect	- the ironman's road: down, only down, and no way home.

Graphics and the Hither Lands tiles

Tiles are chosen in the SDL2 frontend's menu bar, not on the '=' screen. Start the game with the SDL2 interface, load or create a character, then open the menu at the top: FAangband -> Tiles -> Set -> Hither Lands. Under Tiles -> Size, keep the width about twice the height (6x3 suits a 10x20 font). The choice persists. Tile animation and shapechange sprites need no option; they simply happen wherever the tileset provides them.

Keymaps and Preferences

=====

The game can be reshaped to your hand. Two tools matter most: keymaps, which bind a sequence of commands to a single trigger key, and user pref files, which carry your choices between games.

Keymaps

Press '=' and choose "Edit keymaps". There you may query what a key does ('c'), create a new keymap ('d'), or remove one ('e'). Creating one prompts first for the trigger key, then for the action, which is the exact keystrokes to replay; end it with '=' and confirm. Control-u erases the action typed so far.

Keymaps belong to the keyset they were made in: a keymap created under the original keyset is invisible under the roguelike keyset, and each keyset can bind its own action to the same trigger. The '\ ' key bypasses keymaps for one keystroke, and '"' enters a single pref command directly.

A worthwhile example: roguelike players can give the Hither Lands recruit command a key of its own (see the Allies help file), since its default 'j' walks south in that keyset.

Pref files

Keymaps last only for the session unless saved to a pref file from the same '=' menus. Pref files live in your user directory (on Linux, ~/.angband/FAangband) and load automatically in order: the game's defaults, then your race, class, and character-name files, so a keymap can follow one hero alone or all of them. Wrap an action in '(' and ')' to keep -more- prompts from interrupting its replay.



f Skin-Changing: the Full Particulars

=====

"...he took thence the ghastly wolf-hame of Draugluin, and the bat-fell of Thuringwethil."

-- The Silmarillion, ch. 19

*** SPOILERS *** This file lists every shape with its numbers.

If you would rather discover them in play, close this file now. Of Skin-Changing tells a traveller all that is needed and no more, and there is a real pleasure in the first time a fox turns out faster than you had reckoned on. What follows trades that pleasure for the ability to plan. Choose knowingly.

*** SPOILERS BEGIN HERE ***

The notation is plain. Hit/dam/AC are combat modifiers. Named flags are gained while shaped and go again when you revert. Equipment worn keeps all its own powers throughout, in every shape, without exception.

How each shape is gained

No shape comes free. Most are verses, and arrive with the book that holds them, and the levels below are the levels at which the verse may first be learned.

Druid - Fox Form L1 [Lesser Charms]; Become Pukel-man L30, Eagle's Flight L35, Bear Form L40 [Creature Dominion].

Necromancer- Bat Form L3 [Into the Shadows]; Warg Form L28 [Fear and Torment]; Vampire Form L37 [Corruption of Spirit].

Blackguard - Werewolf Form L32 [Fear and Torment].

Beorning - bear at will with '!', cub below L20, bear to L39, great bear from L40.

Anyone - dragon-scale mail's activation turns you into its dragon; certain rarer items grant the beast-forms.

The Druid's is the long road and it ends best. The Necromancer buys early and pays for it in blood. The Blackguard is given one shape and wants no other. The Beorning simply grows into it, which is the only recorded instance in Beleriand of a power arriving on schedule.

Hither Lands in-game help - standard keyset. Roguelike-keyset players: see the in-game help (?) for y

The beast-forms

Ten of them, and no two are meant for the same work.

Fox -3/-3/+3. STR-3, Stealth+5, +1 blow, +1 move;
feather fall, free action. Bite and claw.

The fox is no fighting shape and never becomes one. It is for going somewhere quietly and arriving with your choices still in hand.

Bear cub +5/+5/+0. STR+1, INT-3, infra+3; clumsy paws
(disarming suffers). Four light blows.

A cub strikes four times and thinks about half as well, and the paws are honest about what they cannot manage. It is a beginning.

Bear +10/+10/+2. STR+2, INT-2, CON+1; fearless.
Five blows.

Here the shape stops being a novelty. Fearless means that you will not run, which is either the making of you or the end of you.

Great bear +15/+15/+5. STR+3, INT-2, CON+2, +1 blow;
fearless. Seven blows -- a mill of claws.

Seven blows is less a fight than a weather event. You walk into a room and the room is over.

Eagle +5/+0/+10. +3 moves; flying, trap-immune, sees
the unseen, cannot be blinded, confused, or
frightened; free action. Five rending blows.

The finest travelling shape in the game, and it is not a close contest. Nothing on the floor can reach you and nothing in your head can either.

Bat +0/-10/+10. Speed+3, Stealth+3, infra+5; flying,
trap-immune, sees invisible, cannot be blinded.
Entering costs a little blood. Two weak blows.

The bat can hurt nothing and does not intend to. It is a shape for crossing a level that wants you dead while declining the argument.

Warg +5/+5/+0. +2 blows; entering hurts briefly,
cures fear, and rouses a berserk fury. Four

savage blows.

Putting on the warg is decided in the first second and considered afterwards, or else not at all. The fury is not a thing you choose.

Vampire +3/+3/-5. Speed+5, Stealth+5, infra+5; sees invisible, holds life; your own light dims.
Entering costs a quarter of your health; your bite drinks blood back.

The fastest shape here, bought at a price paid in advance out of your own body, and repaid only if you win. Your light dims because the shape is what it is, and the dark it likes is not the dark you see in.

Werewolf +5/+5/+0. +1 blow, +1 move; regenerating.
Entering terrifies the nearby, cures fear, and rouses fury. Four rending blows.

The room empties before ever you strike. Sauron built a reputation on this shape, and the reputation was fairly earned.

Pukel-man +0/+5/+20. STR+4, CON+4, save+20, damage cut by 10, poison-proof, shard-hard, Speed-5; sustained, regenerating, stun-proof, holds life; cures poison and stunning on entry. Four stone fists.

Stone does not hurry and has no need to. Nobody wears the Pukel-man to chase anything. It is worn to stand immovable in a doorway while the rest of the level breaks itself upon you.

The dragons

Twelve more, and they are one beast wearing twelve different weathers.

All twelve dragon-shapes share one body: +0/+5/+10, Stealth-3, devices+10, throwing-30, four heavy blows -- bite, bite, claw, tear. Re-activate the armour WHILE in dragon-shape to breathe. Each colour keeps its own element, total in its kind:

black acid - blue lightning - white frost - red fire -
green poison

and the high dragons besides: shining (light; sees invisible), law and chaos (hold life), gold (sound; free action, unconfused), multi-hued, balance, and power, whose breaths are as their names.

Hither Lands in-game help - standard keyset. Roguelike-keyset players: see the in-game help (?) for y

The dragon is the loudest thing a traveller can do. Stealth-3 and a body the width of the corridor mean the level knows where you are, and the throwing penalty is the game observing that a dragon has no earthly use for a sling. Breathing while shaped is the point of the whole exercise, and forgetting that you may is the commonest waste in this list.

Practical notes

A few things that the numbers alone will not tell you.

A shape replaces your skills and blows wholesale. A warrior's sword-arm is wasted in a fox, and a druid's fox wastes nothing.

The entry costs of bat, warg, and vampire are paid out of your own body, so do not put on the vampire at a sliver of health.

The Pukel-man trades speed for near-invulnerability, a shape for standing in doorways and not for chasing.

Reverting is free; shifting in is a turn (Beorning) or a song.

None of which is the same thing as knowing what to do. That arrives the first time you shift for the right reason at the right moment, and the level that was going to kill you turns out to have been survivable all along.

Every shape has its own sprite under the Hither Lands tileset, five of them painted for this set alone.